

A Documentary Film by **Erin Lum** 林文欣



LOGLINE

Just By Existing is a 12-minute documentary short that explores cultural disconnection in the Asian Canadian diaspora. Through vibrant mixed-media collage animations, second and third-generation immigrant youth uncover the shame attached to their fragmented cultural identities—and learn to find solace on their own terms.

WATCH THE **PROOF OF CONCEPT** (2022)

SYNOPSIS

Just By Existing is a 12-minute documentary short that explores cultural disconnection in the Asian Canadian diaspora through the voices of Generation Z. Director Erin Lum approaches the film as a personal examination of her own fragmented cultural identity, uncovering this collective experience through intimate interviews with 6 Asian Canadian youth who are second and third-generation immigrants. Their conversations reflect on internalized shame and lack of belonging, crafting complex portraits of racial identity into a mosaic of lived experiences. Stories will be told through live-action footage, voiceovers, and mixed-media collage animations. The collage is a metaphor that informs the experimental composition of the film: if collages are made by combining materials from dissimilar origins, an immigrant's identity is a collage in the same sense. Our existences are made of different cultures that collide and converge, pieces that negotiate and renegotiate their place. The phrase *"You influence culture just by existing"* is offered as a guide for navigating one's cultural identity. The film concludes by capturing Asian Canadian youth engaging in activities that reconnect them to their culture(s)—such as learning to cook a cultural recipe—leaving audiences with a newfound sense of solace and pride.

THEMES

- Cultural & racial identity
- Shame
- Belonging
- Familial relationships



STORY OUTLINE

ACT ONE: Live-Action

We open on the hushed streets of Vancouver's Chinatown to find **ERIN** 林文欣, the filmmaker, standing alone across the street from the Lim Benevolent Association building. The green heritage building stands tall and solemn in her hesitant gaze, as she looks forward in melancholy and contemplation. She crosses the street.

Inside, **ERIN** wanders through the halls of this building rich with life and history. Now empty and quiet, she finds a framed photo of her late Yeye (grandfather) hanging high on the wall, alongside other photographs of Chinese elders and families. She looks up at him with love, but can't help but feel plagued by the literal and symbolic distance between them.

ERIN sets up two chairs facing each other in the space nearby, her Yeye's photo looking over her, and sits down. We see and hear brief glimpses of others entering the room—a soft "hello," a close-up of hands fidgeting on the lap—as other **Asian Canadian youth** sit down across from her. Beginning from a place of tension, the first act situates **ERIN's** examination of her own fragmented cultural identity through the film. As **ERIN** sits, deep in thought, the camera slowly zooms in on her, transforming into an animated reinterpretation of the same image.

STORY OUTLINE

ACT TWO: Mixed Media Animation

Through **voiceovers** and **mixed media collage animations, ERIN** and **6 Asian Canadian youth** recount the complex feelings around being disconnected from their cultures:

- **AUDREY** 周翠薇, a Chinese third-generation immigrant whom Erin has known since birth, as their mothers are best friends. The two daughters reflect on how the pressure their mothers felt to assimilate resulted in Chinese culture *not* being passed down through generations, leaving them to sit with this loss.
- **MIKAELA** 文诗, Erin's eldest cousin, who, like Erin, cannot speak Cantonese. The cousins bond over their shared guilt of rejecting their Chinese identities in childhood: *"How could we ever not be proud to look like our grandparents?"*
- **JOANNE** 박주영, a second-generation immigrant who desired to be white as a child. They reckon with the sobering realization that this self-imposed distancing from their "Koreanness" was a way of coping with strained relationships within their family.

ACT TWO continued -->

STORY OUTLINE

ACT TWO: Mixed Media Animation

- **JOSH**, who grew up in a vibrant Filipino community with kids who looked like him, yet was taunted for being the only one who couldn't speak Tagalog. Made to feel culturally invalid, he ponders how he used to "overcompensate" to prove himself to his community.
- **ANUM** انعم, a Pakistani child of immigrants who has always been uncomfortable with how Canadian society categorizes her as "South Asian," but couldn't understand why. She questions how the ideas of race that have been prescribed to her have ironically made her feel *more* disconnected from her Pakistani heritage.
- **SIMRAN**, a Punjabi third-generation immigrant who feels deeply indebted to her loving family. Since her Dadoo's (grandfather's) passing a few years ago, she fears losing connection to her ancestors, and by extension, her culture.

These conversations will craft intimate portraits of cultural identity through mixed media collage animations. Animations will consist of childhood photos, home videos, and footage from interviews. Voiceovers will be seamlessly edited together to create a mosaic of stories.

ACT TWO continued -->

STORY OUTLINE

ACT TWO: Mixed Media Animation

The participants find solace in knowing that they are carrying forward their cultures and heritage *just by existing.* As second and third-generation immigrants, their identities are like collages. **ERIN** says over voiceover:

"If collages are made by combining materials from dissimilar origins, an immigrant's identity is a collage in the same sense. Our existences are made of different cultures that collide and converge, pieces that negotiate and renegotiate their place."

A vibrant animated visual sweeps across the screen to accompany this quote—representing the amalgamation of identities, stories, and histories shared through these conversations—forming a final collage.

— CUT TO BLACK —

STORY OUTLINE

ACT THREE: Live Action

We return to **ERIN** sitting in the Lim Association building—now revealing the faces of **AUDREY, MIKAELA, JOANNE, JOSH, ANUM,** and **SIMRAN** sitting across from her through quick cuts, having just finished their conversations. They each share meaningful hugs and sentiments.

CUT TO: Verite footage of **AUDREY, MIKAELA, JOANNE, JOSH, ANUM,** and **SIMRAN** engaging in activities that reconnect them to their cultures, such as learning to cook a cultural recipe, dancing together, and interacting with their families.

CUT TO: **ERIN** once again in the Lim Association building. This time, she stands in front of the red and gold ancestral shrine in the main room. We follow her eyes to a single red ancestral tablet on the top row of the shrine. We quickly cut back to the earlier scene of **ERIN** looking at her Yeye's photo on the wall, revealing that this tablet embodies her Yeye. Standing solemnly, she takes three bows—a practice of showing respect to the ancestors in Chinese culture—and exits the frame.

— END —





PARTICIPANTS

The Asian-Canadian youth featured in ***Just By Existing*** are included as they are personally connected to the filmmaker. They are second and third-generation immigrants of Chinese, Korean, Filipinix, Indian, Pakistani, and mixed-Asian descent, and are part of Generation Z (born after 1997). Participants have confirmed their involvement in signed release forms.

Audrey Chow 周翠薇

Joshua Brad-Lee Garrido

Joanne Park 박주영

Simran Sachar

Mikaela Briggs 文诗

Anum Khalid انعم

STYLE + TONE

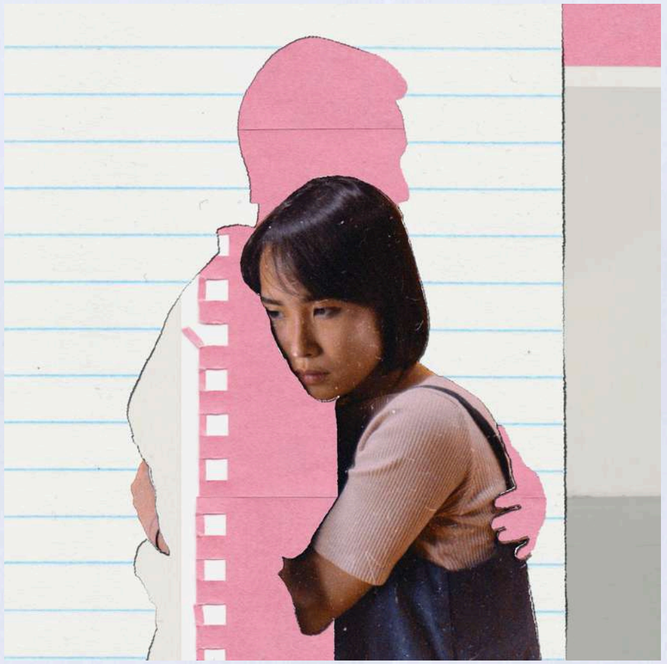
Just By Existing aims to be an introspective journey for all those experiencing it — for the filmmaker, participants, and audiences alike. To reflect this, the film will evoke an **intimate, conversational, and meditative tone**. Because the topic of cultural identity can be emotional, moments of levity will be balanced throughout.

Just By Existing is stylistically different throughout its three acts. A mix of unstructured and semi-staged live-action scenes will open and close the film. Voiceovers of the 6 Asian Canadian participants will guide the narrative and will be edited together in a specific style, where the voices seem to finish each other's sentences. **Mixed media collage animations are the film's main visual language**, where collages are a metaphor for fragmented immigrant identity. These will include a vibrant amalgamation of childhood photos, graphics, illustrations, and home videos. To prioritize the comfort of the subjects and maintain an observational approach, film equipment and lighting set-ups will be kept at a minimum.

To convey the initial themes of cultural shame and isolation, the film's opening section will use a colder colour palette. The mixed media collage animations will introduce a myriad of colours, voices, textures, and sounds. Finally, a newfound sense of solace and reconnection is reflected as the film embraces warmer hues and close-up shots near its ending.

INSPIRATIONS

Filmmaker-Driven Personal Documentaries



LOVE, DAD

Diana Cam Van Nguyen (2021)



NO CRYING AT THE DINNER TABLE

Carol Nguyen (2019)

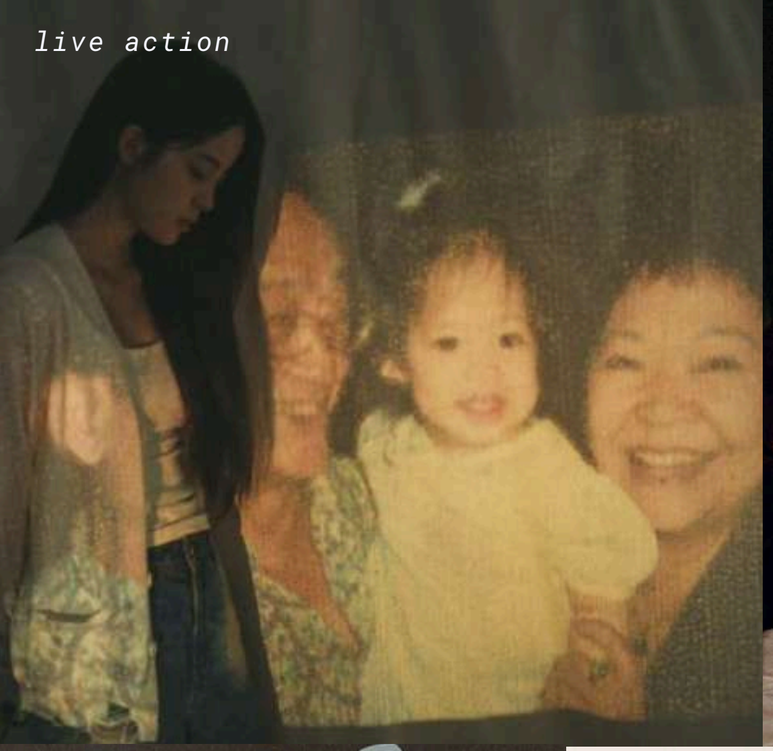


INAY

Thea Loo (2024)

clickable links

live action

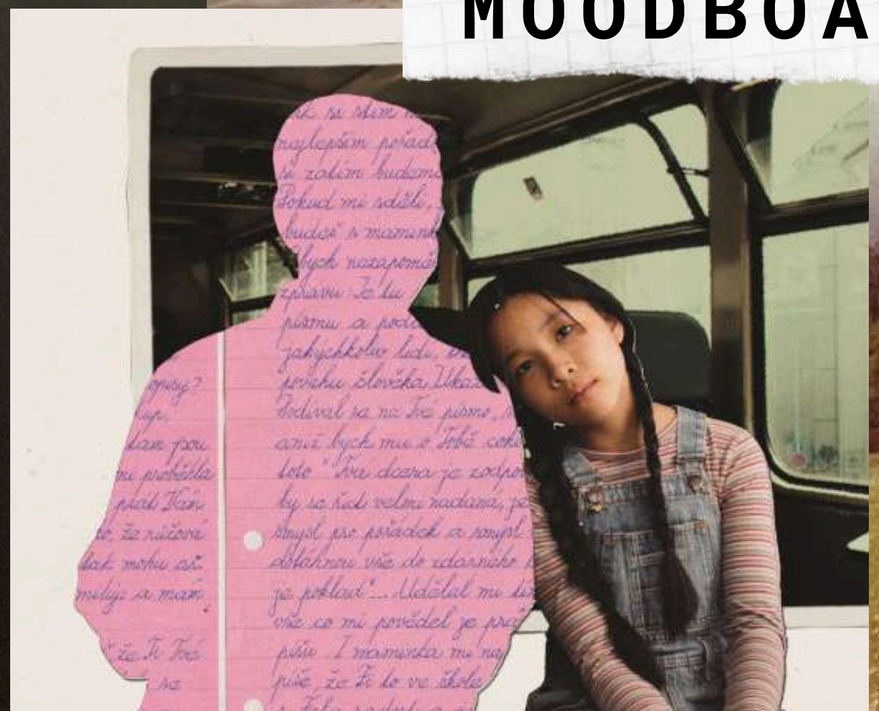






MOODBOARD









mixed media collage animations

DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

Just By Existing is a very personal project — it was born from my own reflections on my relationship with my Chinese identity, as I am a third-generation immigrant who cannot speak Chinese. This disconnection has become a source of complex feelings as I've grown older. I feel flashes of shame often; like the first time I looked at a map of China and could not identify which province my family is from. Or upon being approached by seniors asking for directions in Mandarin, and being met with smug looks when they realize I am unable to answer. And finally, the recent realization that in my 23 years of life, I have never truly seen my grandmother for all she is—her intelligence, mannerisms, and rich stories—because of a language barrier. From conversations with friends, I realized that the feeling of detachment and lack of belonging is a shared experience amongst racialized people and is perhaps felt uniquely by younger generations of immigrants. My inner discontentment with the (lack of) understanding I have of my culture transformed into the idea of creating from this place of tension.

I spent the summer of 2022 exploring these ideas by interviewing 10 of my Asian Canadian friends. These recordings were edited together to create a 6-minute proof-of-concept film, which was projected over 33 mixed-material collages spelling out the quote: "you influence culture *just by existing*" (seen on the title page of this deck).

Making the first iteration of ***Just By Existing*** was a pivotal experience for me both personally and professionally. When the initial project was exhibited at the Art Gallery of Evergreen, I received many emotional responses from audience members of all ages and cultural/diasporic backgrounds. This is a continual reminder of the importance of this story and the driving force behind expanding the film.

I feel as though I haven't scratched the surface of this nuanced topic. I intend to revisit these conversations with more intimacy and depth, weaving together intimate character portraits of my Asian Canadian peers into a mosaic of experiences. The film's construction will be reimagined through mixed media animations. Unlike the first iteration of the project, I will also share my own experiences, family, and personal reflections, which have long weighed heavily on me.

Cultural disconnection is a topic that adds complexity to how we think about the "immigrant experience." It traces the lingering impacts of immigration and cultural shame through generations, bringing to light experiences that are deeply felt but often unspoken within our families and communities. This film acts as an outlet for Asian Canadian youth to define themselves and their experiences, inspiring personal transformation and self-acceptance within the diaspora. ***Just By Existing*** has become a catalyst for a lifelong journey of redefining my Chinese identity. I am incredibly excited to see how it will continue to act as a guide for myself and others as we navigate reconnecting to our cultures.



ABOUT THE DIRECTOR

Erin Lum 林文欣 (she/her) is an emerging filmmaker, dancer, writer, and arts administrator based in Vancouver, BC. She is the current Co-Artistic Director of FORM (Festival of Recorded Movement) and a recent graduate of SFU in Sociology and Communication. Erin is interested in art-making as a powerful form for (re)defining diasporic identity. Her first short film *Zì Jǐ* (2020) has screened internationally, including a week-long projection onto the National Arts Centre building in Ottawa. In 2022, Erin exhibited her multimedia work *Just By Existing* at the Art Gallery at Evergreen (Coquitlam, BC). She is currently expanding this project into a documentary with the support of DOXA Documentary Film Festival.



Photos from ***Just By Existing*** gallery exhibition (2022)



CREATIVE TEAM



Joshua Lam – Producer

Joshua Lam is a Producer, Director, and Writer working in the Vancouver film industry. His stories intersect with self-identity, queerness, family, relationships, and culture through short comics and animated mediums. He recently completed his Canadian Media Producers Association [CMPA] mentorship with Brightlight Pictures. Josh serves as the Lead Creative Producer and was the Acting Director (2025) of the Mighty Asian Moviemaking Marathon (MAMM) hosted by Vancouver Asian Film Festival. He is currently directing his next short film about queerness and Asian familial dynamics with funding from Canada Council for the Arts and BC Arts Council.



Rachel Chen – Director of Photography

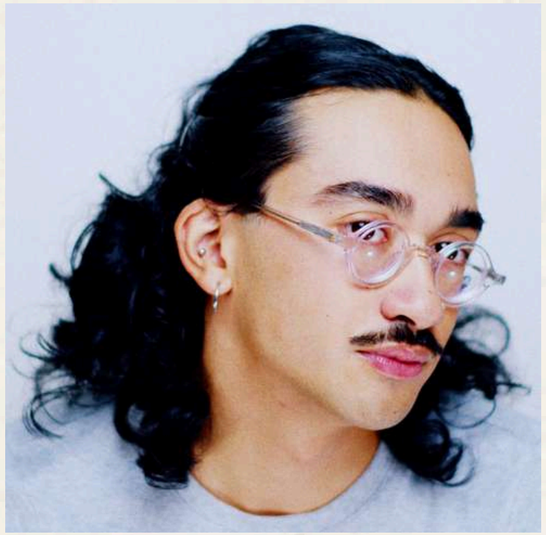
Rachel J. Chen is a Director of Photography based in Vancouver, BC. Her work has screened at festivals such as TIFF Next Wave, NFFTY, St. John’s International Women’s Film Festival, and Vancouver Asian Film Festival. Rachel seeks to illuminate the human experience through intuitive imagery, drawing on her experiences growing up between Xiamen, China and Vancouver. She is a member of the International Cinematographers Guild and an affiliate member of the Canadian Society of Cinematographers.

CREATIVE TEAM



Ella Saini – Mixed Media Animator

Ella Saini (she/they) is a Filipino-Indian Canadian filmmaker based in Scarborough, ON. Working primarily in documentary and mixed media animation, her practice explores the intricate relationships between people and their environments, spotlighting narratives within marginalized communities. Their latest short *unhome*, a documentary about gentrification in Scarborough, was screened at the 2024 TIFF Next Wave. Ella is currently co-directing and animating *Hiroshimas Per Second*, a short documentary about climate anxiety, alongside Chen Sing Yap. The project won the Reel Asian So You Think You Can Pitch competition in 2024.



Joshua Brad-Lee Garrido – Editor

Joshua Brad-Lee Garrido is a Filipino-Canadian filmmaker & interdisciplinary artist from Treaty 7, Mohkinstsis (Calgary, Alberta), currently residing in Vancouver, BC. They are a recent graduate of U of Calgary (BComm) and UBC (BFA Film Production). Their work explores how the moving image can explore identity & emotionality, amplified by sampling their archive of influences through a sentimental, impressionistic lens. Their film *Chrome* (2024) has been showcased as part of the 2025 NYU Sports Film Festival, Cannes Indie Shorts Film Festival, FORM (Festival of Recorded Movement), and nominated for the Canadian Society of Cinematographers (CSC) Student Cinematography Award. They are currently developing their first feature film, *MUSE*.

FESTIVAL STRATEGY

Shorts & Documentary Festivals

DOXA Documentary Film Festival (Vancouver)	Jan 8 2027
Hot Docs (Toronto)	Jan 8 2027
TIFF Next Wave	Feb 1 2027
IDFA (International Documentary Festival Amsterdam)	April 24 2027
Toronto International Film Festival	May 9 2027
Vancouver International Film Festival	May 15 2027
Images Festival (Toronto)	Aug 21 2027
AMDOCS: American Doc & Animation FF (California)	Oct 12 2027
Doc Edge Festival (New Zealand)	Dec 15 2027

Community Screenings

As this film is fundamentally rooted in community, sharing it at familiar community spaces/events is a priority *to meet audiences where they are*. For Asian Heritage Month, we will host a **Private Community Screening** for participants' family and friends in **May 2027** at the Lim Sai Hor Kow Mock Benevolent Association's heritage building in Vancouver Chinatown (Community Partner), with future screenings to be arranged.

Asian Diaspora Focused-Festivals

Asian American International Film Festival (New York)	March 15 2027
San Diego Asian Film Festival	April 20 2027
Reel Asian Film Festival (Toronto)	May 18 2027
Vancouver Asian Film Festival	May 22 2027
DisOrient Asian American Film Festival (Oregon)	Nov 21 2027
Los Angeles Asian Pacific Film Festival	Dec 1 2027
Seattle Asian American Film Festival	Dec 20 2027
Mint Chinese Film Festival (UK)	Dec 25 2027
IAWRT Asian Women's Film Festival (India)	Dec 31 2027
FascinAsian Film Festival (Calgary, Edmonton, Winnipeg)	Jan 18 2028
Diaspora Film Festival (Korea)	Jan 23 2028